

Counting Mangos

“...Twenty one, then?”

“Mmm, I count twenty three.”

“Impossible, those two are dead.”

“You always count the dead ones.”

“No you don’t.”

“You do,” she says. “As long as they are still on the tree.”

“Yes, but you don’t eat the dead ones,” I explain.

“Sure, but they are still there.”

“My God you’re impossible.”

We pick twenty one mangos, leaving the two dead ones. We carry them along the shore in a canvas bag, the waves rolling in, tipping over and crashing past the reef. Up the beach, we see a white masted sailboat cutting the blue water.

“Would you count dead horses?” I ask.

“Now why on Earth would I do that?”

She laughs and takes a mango from the bag, prying it open, tearing the meat from the seed. She eats the flesh from the skin and discards it along with the seed into the ocean. The boat is closer now, a single sail, filled with several men straining rope against the westward gusts.

“Would you count that one?” I ask, pointing to the mango remains rising in the swash.

“Which one?”

“The one you just ate. Does that make it twenty or twenty one?”

“I said there were twenty three.”

I start to argue but she takes my hand.

“Darling, you’re much too concerned by the fine discrepancies. These things are nothing but made up ideas, you don’t have to believe in any of it. What we choose to concern ourselves with is exactly what our lives become, don’t you think so? Is your life really one that cares if I like to count the dead mangos?”

Offshore, a strong wind fills the sail, teetering the catboat on a sharp differential. The boat capsizes, the young men shouting and leaping into the bright water. One swims to the hull and stands on the exposed keel. The others join and swim the ropes out. They heave and the mast starts to lift from the water, the sea raining down from the wet cloth. A moment later, it all swings upright, settling along with the sun, the white sail, the blue swells reflecting the strung about clouds. The men climb aboard, whipping back their wet hair. We can hear them cheer from the shore.

“No,” I say at last.

She takes another mango from the canvas and begins to peel it with her nails.

“Then be a good little darling and stop all that talking.”